



Still Bears Her Name

Tracking Label-Refiller Match Across a Shared Kitchen’s Spice Rack

Runa Adegoke · Petra Umbile — School of Emergent Priorities

Motivation

Shared kitchens rely on a jar’s handwritten label to signal who restocks it. Once written, a label routinely outlives the arrangement it recorded. How far can a name drift from the hand that refills it before anyone revises it?

Research questions

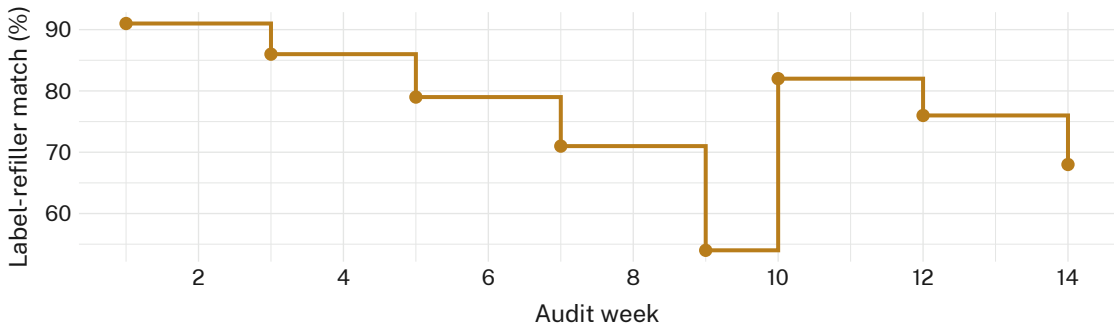
- Classify labelled jars by name-refiller match status across shared kitchens
- Track how long a mismatch persists before the label is revised
- Test whether visible depletion, rather than elapsed time, triggers relabeling

Study design

- n = 214 labelled jars · 9 share-house and office pantries · fortnightly photo audit · 14 weeks
- Refill events logged via a discreet fill-line sticker, matched against the label’s named owner by self-report
- Relabeling events (handwriting change) coded as a revision; no threshold was adjusted post hoc

What we found

Match rate holds flat between relabeling events and steps in a single jump at each revision, rather than declining continuously. A jar’s declared owner outlasts their last refill by a median 5 weeks before the label is updated.



Aggregate label-refiller match fell from 91% in week 1 to 54% by week 9, recovering only after a fortnightly kitchen clean-up (week 10) relabelled 61% of mismatched jars in a single afternoon.

Implications

Ownership claims persist by default; revision needs an external trigger, not accumulating mismatch. A label functions as a governance artefact independent of the practice it once described. Next: test whether a QR-linked digital label revises itself automatically.

Selected references

1. Pierce, J. L., Kostova, T., & Dirks, K. T. (2003). The state of psychological ownership: Integrating and extending a century of research. *Review of General Psychology*, 7(1), 84–107. doi:10.1037/1089-2680.7.1.84
2. Brown, G., Lawrence, T. B., & Robinson, S. L. (2005). Territoriality in organizations. *Academy of Management Review*, 30(3), 577–594. doi:10.5465/AMR.2005.17293710
3. Neumayr, T., Augstein, M., & Kubicek, B. (2022). Territoriality in hybrid collaboration. *Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction*, 6(CSCW2). doi:10.1145/3555224
4. Pollak, R. A. (2007). Bargaining around the hearth. *NBER Working Paper* No. 13142. doi:10.3386/w13142
5. Cardenas, J. C. (2011). Social norms and behavior in the local commons as seen through the lens of field experiments. *Environmental and Resource Economics*, 48(3), 451–485. doi:10.1007/s10640-010-9452-8

De-identified by jar only; no householder was named or approached. Fill-line data destroyed at audit close.

Contact: runa.adegoke@slop.university · Office of Research Outputs

🐦 @slop.university · #slopU



“The label outlived the hand that wrote it.”

Match rate fell from 91% to 54% over nine weeks (n = 214 jars, 9 kitchens) before a scheduled clean-up reset it in an afternoon.